



Bound together by the web

Meet up with friends and keep in touch...

Rossi Fernandes
rossi.fernandes@thinkdigit.com

The internet's vast spread has made the world a smaller place. People have forgotten postal mail completely by now. Communicating over the internet is much simpler, quicker and is much more reliable than traditional mail. The speed of delivery is one of the advantages of communicating over the internet. While emails are very quick, real instant messengers deliver messages instantaneously, or at least as soon as the other party comes online. Services have sprung up since the very beginning of the internet. At first, there was something called IRC, which then gave way to instant messengers. ICQ was one of the first services that gave the user an identity in the form of a UIN (Unified Identification Number).

The dependence on service providers for your instant messaging needs is perfectly fine. They are, for the most part reliable, but what if you wanted your own service? Having your own service has it's own advantages. It gives you additional flexibility and virtually unlimited ability to add extra functions that you might need.

The oldest and the best – IRC

IRC (Internet Relay Chat) was one of the earliest ways of communicating across the internet. The main advantage of IRC is the ability to converse with many people at the same time. Some of the instant messaging services have group

chat features but they are nowhere as advanced as IRC. IRC works mainly on group chat. The first thing you do is join an IRC channel filled with people. Private messages can also be sent the same way as instant messages. It was developed in 1988 and has been used for all kinds of purposes other than conversations between users at home.

IRC works like any other instant messenger. It runs on a server program that users connect to using IRC clients. mIRC, Hydra IRC, XChat are examples of IRC clients. Multiple servers are usually interconnected over the internet to create a network. Users can connect to any of the servers to join the network. If one goes down, there are still others that users can connect to.

For the sake of keeping everything organised, there are channels set up so that people with a common topic to chat about can join a particular channel. So, you might find a channel dedicated to playing the guitar or 3D modelling or programming, or any other hobby for that matter. Users can also join many channels at the same time. Modern day IRC clients also allow users to join multiple servers.

Why is all of this of any importance to us? Well, Digit will soon be setting up its own IRC server and channels. We will have an IRC server very soon and a channel set up so that you can chat with each other and with us. We'll show you how to connect to this server a little later.

The IRC community is huge and has continued to exist even while various instant messenger services have come and gone. Every good online community today has an IRC channel on an IRC server some place or the other. It lets users chat on a particular topic in ways that might not always be possible on a forum. People come closer by participating in other activities as well, such as games. For many, it's almost like a social network and people often stay on the channel all through the day. They aren't necessarily in front of the PC all the time but their IRC clients are always connected.

Setting up the IRC server

Like any other open protocol, the IRC server isn't developed by a single firm or development group. There are many of them for each platform. For the sake of this demonstration, we'll be using Inspire IRCd. The great thing about Inspire IRCd is that it's available for Linux as well as



The InspIRCd control panel running

Windows. It's also really simple to set up. Most IRC server daemons run in a very similar manner, so you can use IRC server daemons of your choice.

Inspire IRC can be downloaded from www.inspircd.org, and installation should not cause any problems. Just select all the default options and complete the installation. Most of the settings for the server are done to the configuration file. In Windows, the file is stored in the InspIRCd\conf folder under the path where you installed the application.

The IRC daemon starts with an interface that gives you basic control over the system. If you try to start the server by clicking the Start button, InspIRCd will show an error message. The server comes with a default configuration file. In this case it's called `inspircd.conf.example`. Make a copy of it and rename it to `inspircd.conf`. You may have to use Wordpad, or a better text editor such as EditPad Lite, to edit this file in order to avoid word wrapping issues that might arise with Notepad.

Scroll down to DIE/
RESTART CONFIGURATION
and add a password to the
line. The die password is
the one required to shut the
server down and the restart
password is for restarting the
server. Replace the _____
with the passwords.

```
<power diepass="_____  
_____" restartpass="_____  
_____" pause="2">
```

Next, move to the server information tag. This tag contains the server name, it's description and the network to which it belongs. This is the text that shows up when the user connects to your server. Fill in the details for your server.